



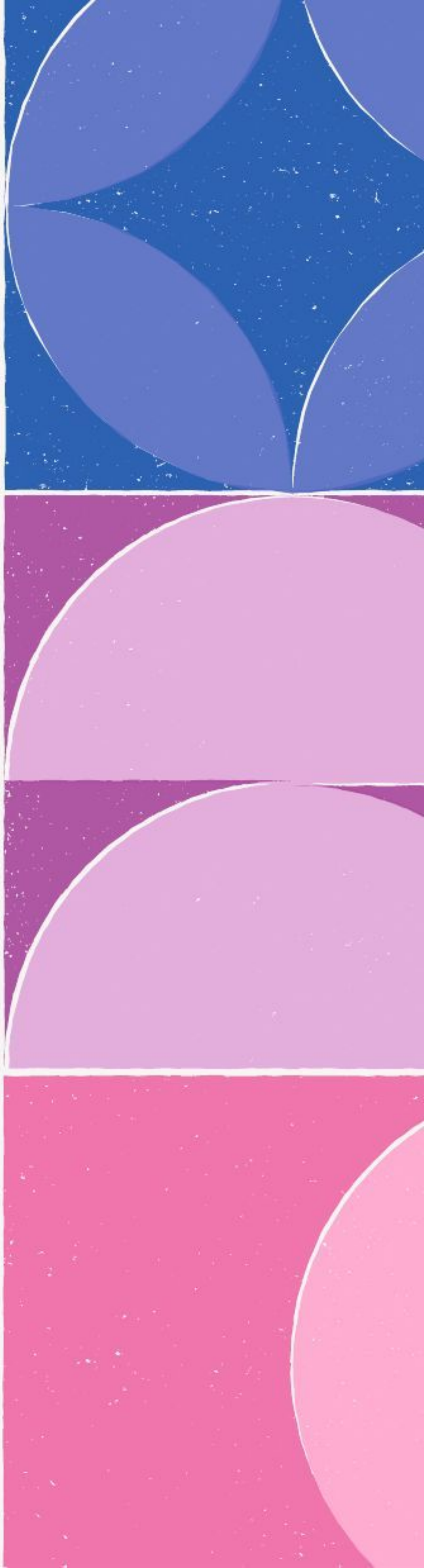
Yale LGBTQ+ Mental Health Initiative

LGBT

Voices and Visions

Mapping Community Needs
and
Evaluating Academic Collaborations

Meredith McGee
August 23, 2024

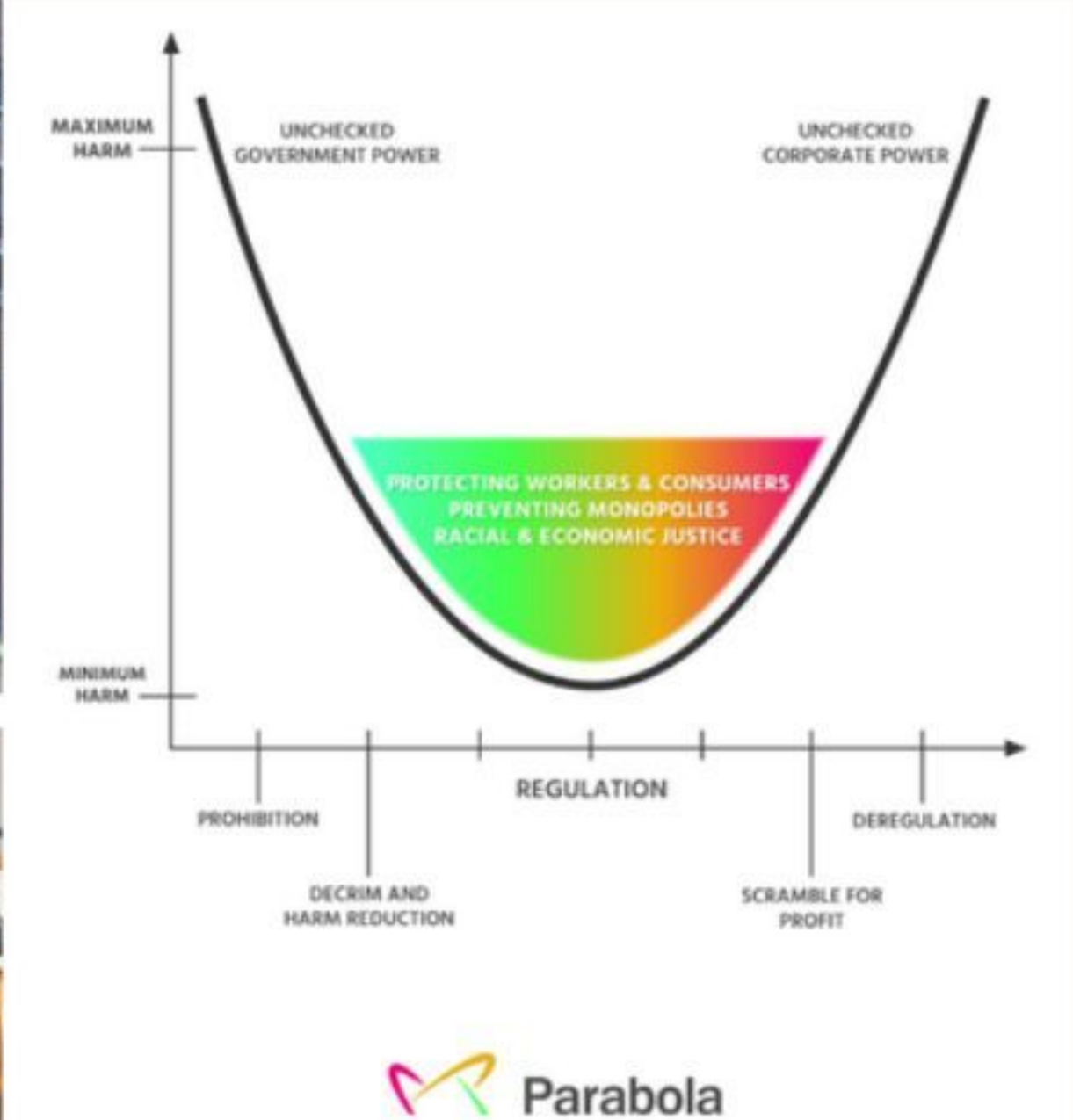


Who I Am

- 2nd year MPH Student
- Interested in mental health, substance use, and LGBTQ+ community health
- Grants and Funding Specialist, Bradbury-Sullivan LGBT Community Center

Things I've Done

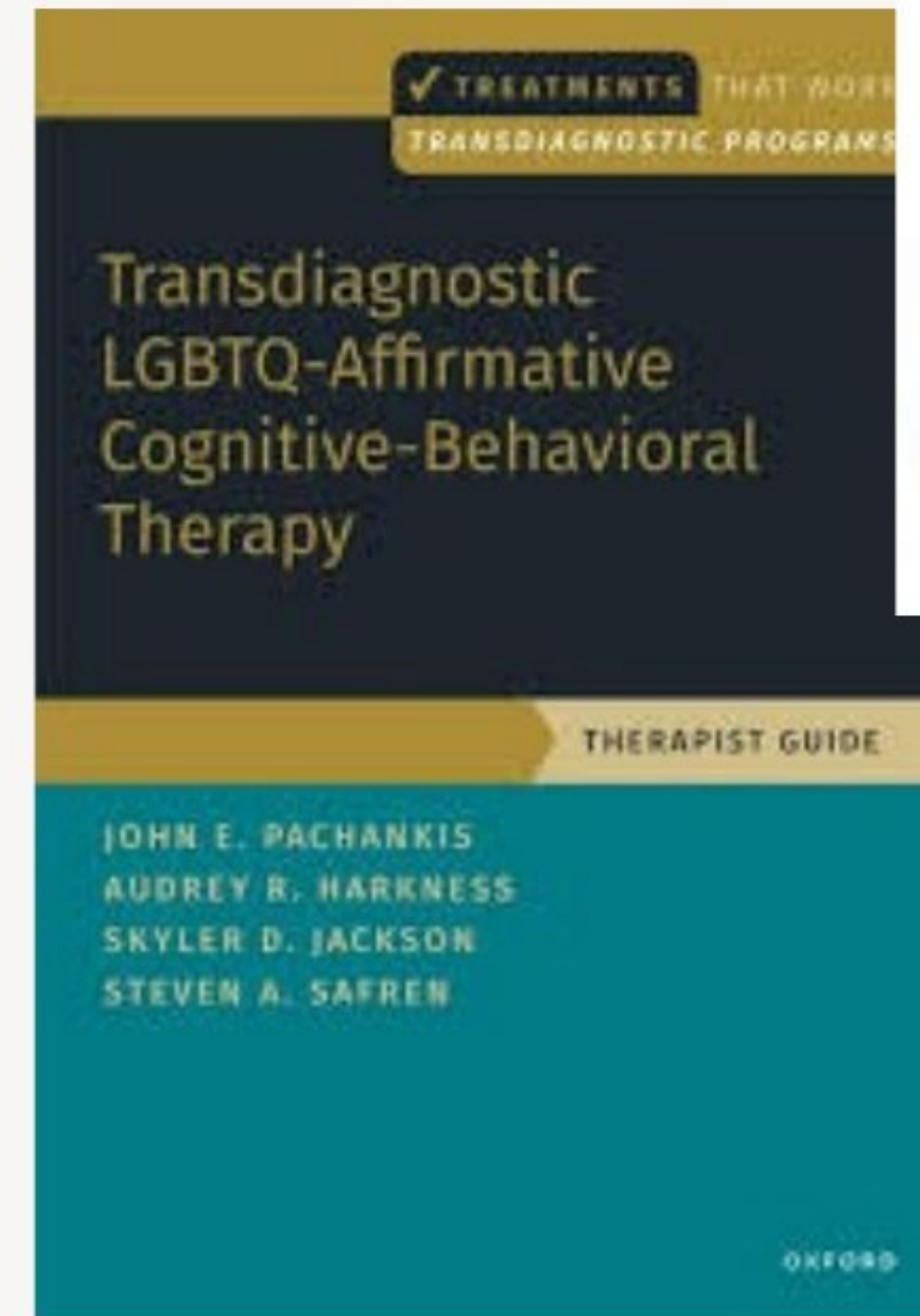
- Secured over \$500,000 in grants for LGBTQ+ programming initiatives
- Founded the first gender-neutral housing option at Lafayette College
- Honors Thesis on LGBTQ+ erotica development



LGBTQ MHI Strategic Plan: 2023-2024

Provide Training in LGBTQ-Affirmative CBT to Mental Health Providers

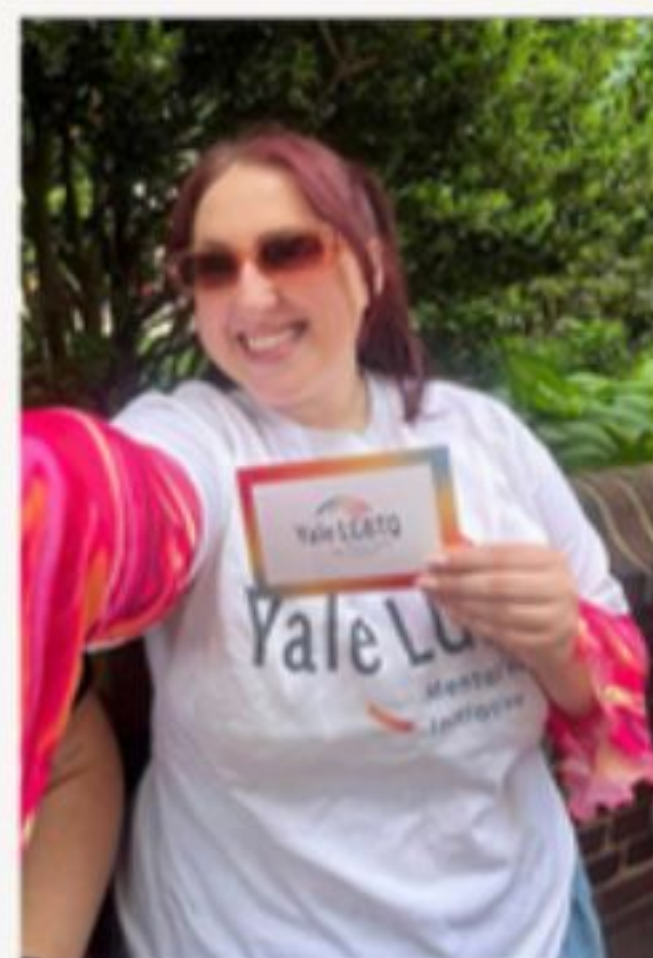
- Hire staff necessary to develop and implement training
- Provide ongoing, virtual, and on-site training opportunities to LGBTQ mental health providers
- **Support LGBTQ mental health organizations in collecting and evaluating their own data to improve service delivery.**



LGBTQ MHI Strategic Plan: 2023-2024

INCREASE VISIBILITY OF OUR INITIATIVE IN THE COMMUNITY

- Develop a cohesive brand for the Yale LGBTQ Mental Health Initiative that is recognizable, intentional, and memorable in the NYC community.
- Be more present at community events hosted by local LGBTQ organizations to help build partnerships for future collaborations.



What I Wanted to Do

01

Community
Capacity Needs
Assessment

02

Community
Partnership
Evaluations

03

Piloting a
Community-
Academic
Partnership

Creating A...

01

Community Capacity Needs Assessment

01

Creating A Community Capacity Needs Assessment

Why is it needed?

- Expansion in LGBTQ+ services around the USA
- Yet many organizations operate in silos
- Seeking to identify and understand similar strengths, threats, and opportunities

Why is it different?

- Focused not just on what they offer
 - Focus on what they **want** to offer
- Seeks to understand what they do best and what they see for the future
- Uplifting experiences and stories over metrics and statistics

What is Out There?

2022 LGBTQ COMMUNITY CENTER SURVEY REPORT

The Impact and Infrastructure of Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, and Queer Community Centers

November 2022



CENTERLINK
THE COMMUNITY OF LGBTQ CENTERS



Participant Demographics

- Community organizations that serve LGBTQ+ Individuals in NJ, NY, or CT
 - Initial outreach list: 75 organizations
- Of those interviewed:
 - The majority had an operating budget under \$5 million
 - The majority had 25 or fewer paid staff positions
 - **8** provided mental health care*
 - **6** had an HIV focus**
 - **7** had youth programs
 - **10** Hosted community-based groups
 - **4** had a Harm Reduction Focus
 - **9** provided navigational support



* broadly defined, including social work, drop in care, etc

** defined as testing, care, case management, etc

The Interview

Interview Comprised of:

- Organizational Overview
- 7 Open-Ended Questions
- “Menu” analysis

All interviews were between 25-60 minutes long.

The interview structure was adapted from the University of Kansas’ Community Tool Box.

- Modified SWOT analysis found in Chapter 3 Section 14

3. Core Questions

a. Strengths

- i. What are the strongest aspects of your organization and its work?
- ii. What would you say is your most successful program? What strategies contribute to its success?

b. Opportunities

- i. What opportunities do you see for expanding or improving services for the LGBTQ+ community?
- ii. Are there any emerging trends or developments within the community that your organization should address?

c. Collaboration

- i. How does your organization collaborate with other community groups or organizations?
- ii. Have any partnerships been particularly effective or beneficial?

d. Resource Availability

- i. What resources (financial, human, technical) does your organization currently have?
- ii. What additional resources do you think are needed to better serve the community?

e. Service Gaps

- i. What gaps do you see in the current services provided to the LGBTQ+ community?
- ii. What specific needs are not being met by existing services?
- iii. What do you think is preventing these needs from being met?

**Educating
Others**

**Transgender
and Non-Binary
Inclusion**

Highlighted Themes

**The Need for Mental
Health Care**

Educating Others

Key Aspects:

- 55% of organizations interviewed had formalized education programs
- Varied methods and targets for educational efforts
 - Formal programs in schools and partnerships with institutions
 - Internal education for staff to maintain cultural competence
 - Education of external stakeholders (funders, officials) on LGBTQ+ needs
 - Community-based education
- Research a large role in many organizations

“ [The educational programming] creates opportunity for community education and professional development through trainings and workshops for school districts, private agencies, nonprofits, government agencies, and formal and informal groups across Connecticut. The purpose of the Training Institute is to strengthen LGBTQ+ cultural competency and increase LGBTQ+ individuals' access to inclusive and affirming services and environments.”

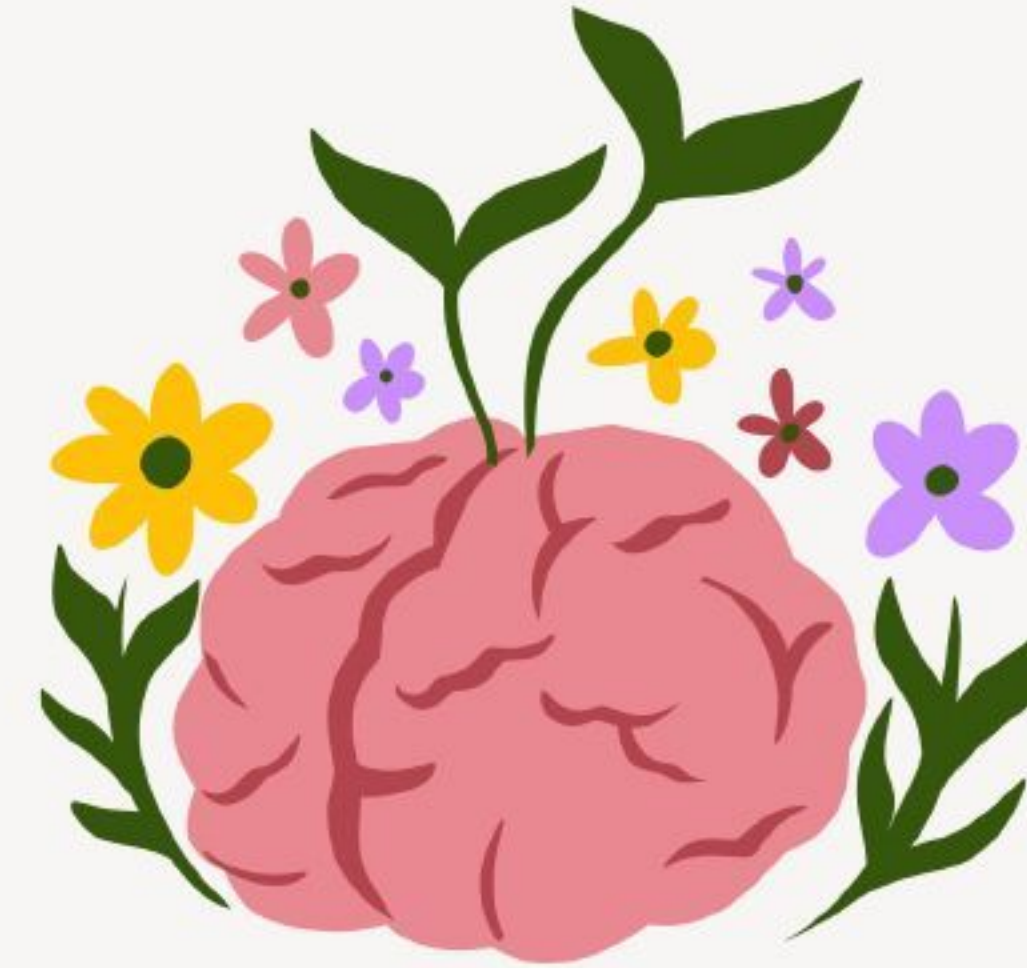


The Need for Mental Health Care

"We are really trying to center all of the ways we are challenging oppression within the medical model and the clinical space"

Key Aspects:

- 73% of organizations offer specific mental health services
- Challenges in recruiting LGBTQ+-experienced professionals
- Use of therapy and social work interns to meet demand
- Free services often provided, relying on external funding



"We've almost tripled the size of our counseling department over the last couple of years... We're responding like everybody else to the huge need for mental health services"

Transgender and Non-Binary Inclusion



Key Aspects:

- Significant influx in demand for TGN-specific services
- Need for representative staff and culturally competent care
- Lack of data on TGN experiences and outcomes

"The Trans community continues to face all kinds of barriers and stigma. So I would say that those two [communities of color and trans community] primarily are where our challenges lie."

"We are seeing sometimes a little bit of a deviation from LGB and leaning more into the TGNC or TGE population to serve in general."

"We recently hired on a full-time trans and non-conforming staff person because we've seen a big influx in folks from the trans community reaching out to us. And we wanted to have someone on the staff more full-time to work with those kids. So that's both from a mental health perspective as well as a community-building perspective."

Expansion and Sustainability



Funding Challenges



Other Themes

Generational Gaps



Political and Social Pressure

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02

Community Partnership Evaluations

02

Community Partnership Evaluations

The Shawn Lang Legacy HIV Health Equity and Social Justice Fellowship (HESJF)

- Established in 2022 in honor of Shawn Lang
- Designed for MPH students to support either
 - Practice-based project focused on HIV and the community
 - Research-based project working with a CIRA researcher

3 Years , 8 Interns, 5 Organizations

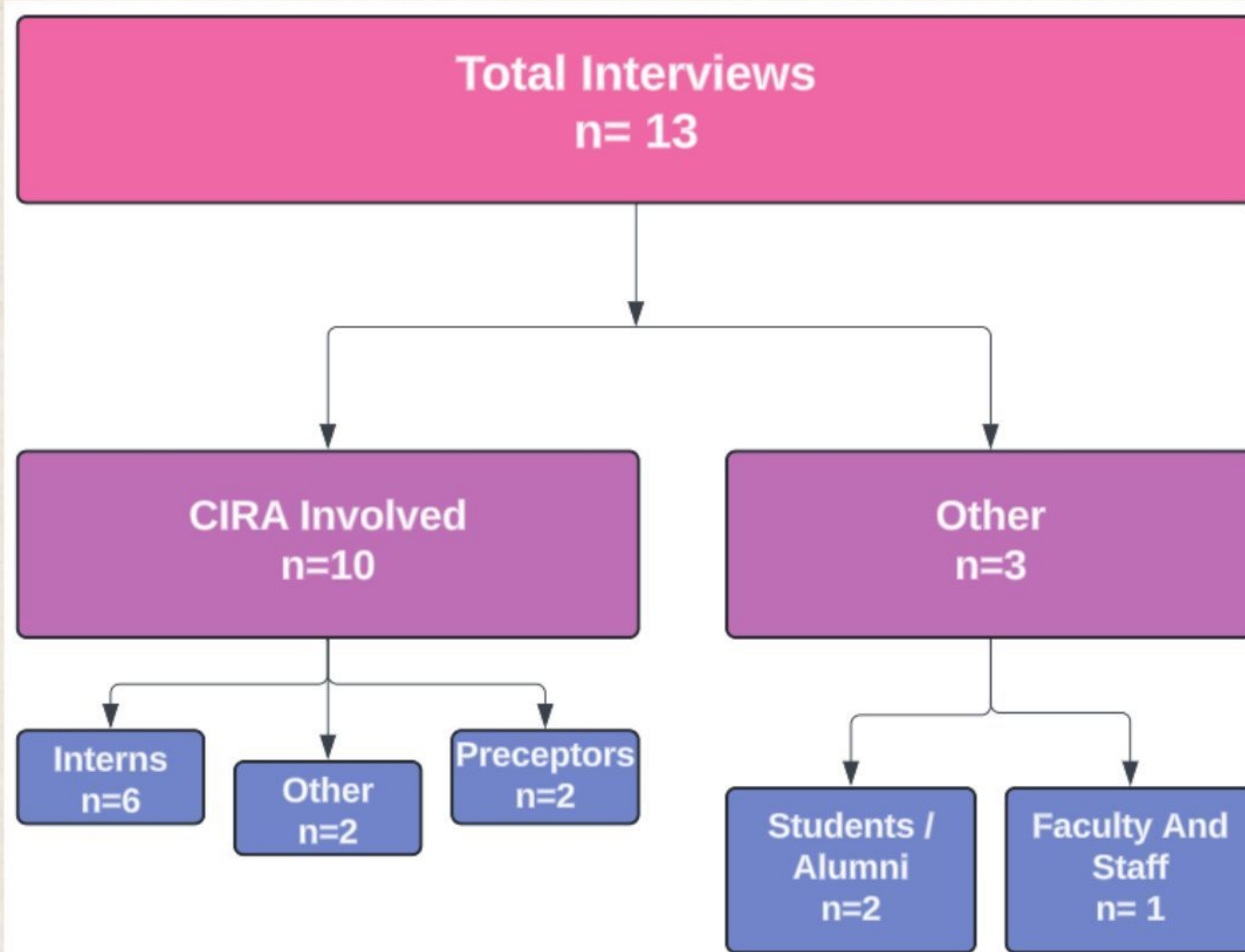
Shawn Lang

1956-2021



Shawn Lang was a leading advocate for HIV/AIDS, LGBTQ rights, and opioid prevention, serving as Deputy Director of Advancing CT Together (ACT) for over 30 years. Her work earned her national recognition, including the White House Champion of Change award.

Participant Demographics



- 8 interns interviewed
 - 6 CIRA involved
- 2 Preceptors interviewed
- 3 staff

The Interview

8 Open-ended questions

All interviews 25-45 minutes long

Focused on:

- Internship search + selection
- Experience with Preceptor
- Experience with Yale
- Impact of Work

Different variations based on the interviewee's background

4. Student Internship Questions

- a. These questions will ask you to reflect specifically on your own YSPH internship.
 - i. What was the internship search process like for you?
 1. When / where did you start looking? Did you use any YSPH resources? Did you use any personal resources / already established relationships?
 - ii. Can you tell me a little bit about your internship?
 1. Where was it? What was your job? What were the deliverables?
 - iii. What skills did you use the most during your internship? Did you feel well equipped to do these skills during your internship?
 - iv. What aspects of the internship did you find most valuable?
 - v. Can you share an example of a successful project or task you completed during your internship?
 - vi. What challenges did you face during your internship, and how did you overcome them?
 1. Did / could YSPH help you overcome these challenges? How?
 - vii. What opportunities could have improved your experience in the internship process?
 1. What could YSPH have done to improve your internship experience?
 - viii. How do you think your work benefited the host organization or community?
 1. Were there any lasting impacts or projects that continued beyond your internship? Did you continue a relationship with your host organization?



Communication

Themes Found

Structure



Expectations

Structure

“[The Internship] had zero structure. A lot of the impetus fell on the fellows to kind of design the internship into what they wanted it to be, which I think can be good, to have some liberty in terms of what you want to focus on. But there have to be some structure and guidelines to ensure that you have things to do every day.”

Key Aspects

- Unstructured internship experiences across placements
- Mixed reactions from fellows
- Self-directed project development and execution
- Importance of being a "self-starter"

Impact

- Some fellows thrived in autonomous settings
- Others found the lack of structure challenging
- Success is dependent on the ability to navigate an unstructured environment

Communication

"I felt chastised constantly, so any interaction I felt like I was being scolded..."

"There was no instruction, there was no follow-up. There was no, okay, here's your team, here's your projects, whatever..."

Key Aspects:

- Perceived critical and prescriptive communication toward community partners
- Ambiguity in deadlines and tasks
- Inconsistent communication with host sites and preceptors

Impact:

- Frustration and disempowerment among preceptors
- Fellows feeling disconnected from their roles
- Difficulty in planning and managing interns' workload
- The overall effectiveness of the internship program affected

Expectations

"They had expectations that they did not share with us. So at the end of the internship [staff member] is like 'okay send me all your deliverables'. And I was like 'well, I didn't really have any'."

"I wanted to perform so well, and I felt like I disappointed Yale, and I was disappointed that we didn't get to offer them all I thought we could."

"If [expectations] were clear then [the internship] would have been a little easier because I wouldn't have had such high expectations of myself in particular, and that I was doing something not right."

Key Issues:

- Lack of well-defined expectations prior to internship start
- Misalignment between expected research work and community-based experiences
- Confusion about the program's primary purpose (social justice vs. student experience)
- Host organizations feeling unprepared and unclear about requirements
- Tension between expectations and host organizations' understanding

Community Impact

Key Findings:

- Varied levels of tangible outcomes across cohorts
- Shift from student-centered to community-focused outcomes
- Range of deliverables: reports to community health initiatives
- Evolution of perceived impact over program duration
- Recent cohorts showing more meaningful community impact
- Internship length limits sustained change potential

"[Student] elevated the data literacy and the way [the organization] does quality work... which has inspired some other folks in the organization to take a more data-driven approach to their programs."





Reflection on Themes

03

Piloting a Community-Academic Partnership

Using the first two aims....

How Do We Improve Community-Yale
Relations in regards to the LGBTQ+
community?

First....

People need to know what an MPH
student does and what they can do!

Yale School of Public Health Community Partnership Services

Welcome to our comprehensive menu of services provided by Yale MPH students aimed at enhancing the capacity and efficacy of LGBTQ+ organizations. This menu outlines the diverse skill sets and support that our students can offer, helping your organization achieve its goals and better serve the community.

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Data Analysis

- **Description:** Analyzing collected data to inform program planning and policy making. This involves using statistical software to analyze quantitative data and coding qualitative data to identify themes, ensuring that findings are presented in a clear and actionable manner.
- **Example Activities:** Data cleaning, statistical analysis, coding qualitative data, interpreting results, preparing comprehensive reports with visual aids (charts, graphs).

Feedback From Menu

Mostly Positive

- Explains an MPH intern well
- Accessible format and easy-to-understand
- Grounds partnerships in a specific project
- Likes the fact that Yale seems more involved

- Need more “nitty-gritty” information to be effective
- Concerns over getting to know organizations well enough
- Cultural Understanding Concerns

Recommendations for A Community-Academic Partnership

1. Place the Relationship Between Yale and the Organization

Recommendation: Establish relationships directly between Yale and the organization to ensure continuity and sustained collaboration.

2. Value Organizational Experience

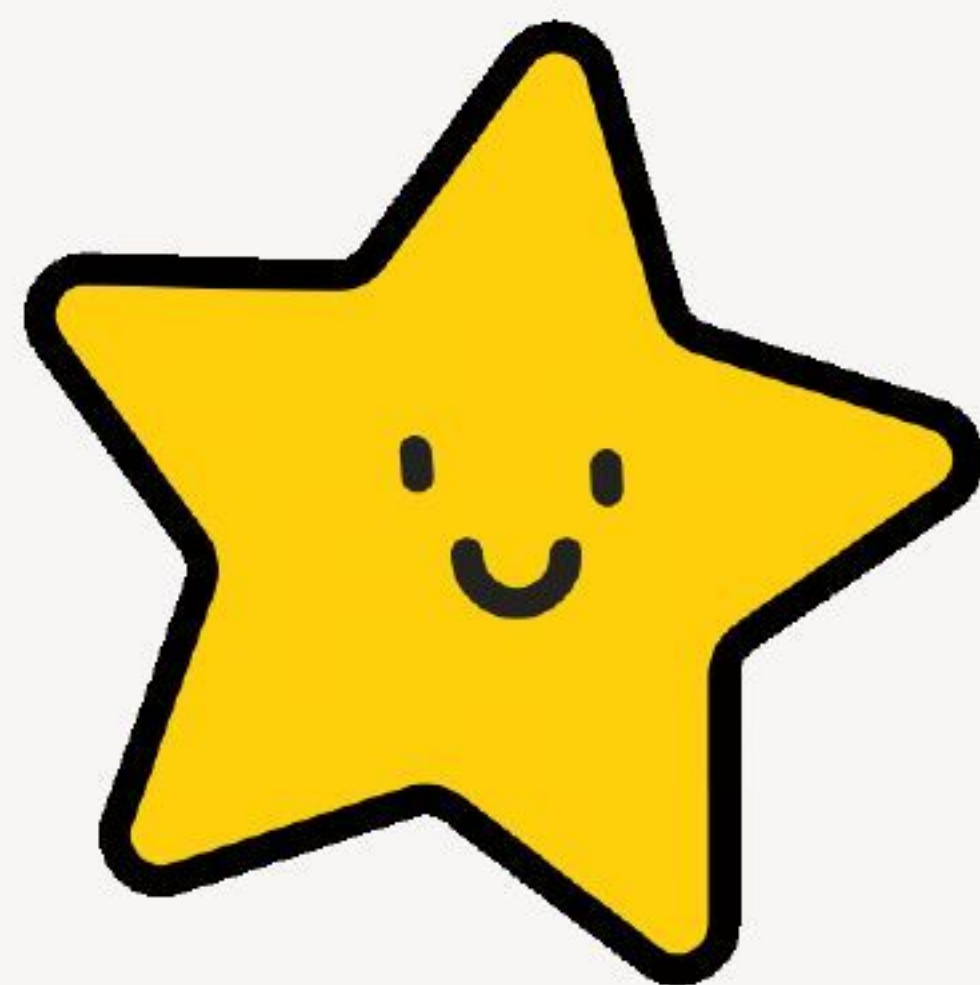
Recommendation: Place high value on the organization's experience and ensure that project goals align with community needs and strengths.

4. Clear Expectations

Recommendation: Define clear roles, responsibilities, and expectations from the outset, ensuring all parties are on the same page. "Define the MPH"

5. Longer Partnerships, But More Defined Projects

Recommendation: Focus on developing longer-term partnerships with more clearly defined projects that can evolve over time, ensuring sustainability and deeper community impact.



THANKS

Questions?